Rules of Negation

Basic Construction

To make a sentence negative, surround the primary verb with “**ne**” and “**pas**”. However, 'ne' contracts to 'n'' when followed by a word starting with a vowel or a **mute 'h'**.

Je parle français. → Je **ne** parle **pas** français.
J’aime le café. → Je **n’**aime **pas** le café.

Definite Articles

With the definite articles (le, la, l’, les) as well as its contractions (au, aux, du, des), there is **no change when it comes to negation.**

Omission of Partitive and Indefinite Articles

In general, we contract the partitive or indefinite articles to “de” or “ d’ ” while using it in negative sentences.

Indefinite Articles

The indefinite articles (un, une, des) become **“de” or “ d’ ”** after pas (except for “être” and the verbs of state).

Partitive Articles

Partitive articles (du, de la, de l’, des) also become **“de” or “ d’ ”** after pas (except for “être” and the verbs of state).

Français	English
Je veux **de la** pizza. (partitive article) Je ne veux pas **de** pizza.	I want some pizza. I don't want pizza.
Elles ont **des** ordinateurs. (indefinite article) Elles n’ont pas **d**’ordinateurs.	They have some computers. They don’t have any computers.
Nous achetons **une** voiture. Nous n’achetons pas **de** voiture.	We are buying a car. We are not buying a car.

Exceptions - Être and Verbs of State (Les Verbes d’État)

We **do not contract** the indefinite or partitive articles with the de or d’ with the verbs of state. The indefinite or partitive articles used while forming negative sentences using the verbs of state remain the same.

Les Verbes d’État : être, rester, sembler, devenir, paraître, demeurer, avoir l’air

Français	English
Il reste **un** ami loyal. (indefinite article) Il ne reste pas **un** ami loyal.	He's still a loyal friend. He is no longer a loyal friend.
C'est **de l**'huile d'olive. (partitive article) Ce n'est pas **de l**'huile d'olive.	It is olive oil. It is not olive oil.
Elle est devenue **une** grande danseuse. Elle n'est pas devenue **une** grande danseuse.	She has become a great dancer. She has not become a great dancer.
Il a l'air d'**un** criminel. Il n'a pas l'air d'**un** criminel.	He seems like a criminal. He does not seem like a criminal.

The indefinite and partitive articles are indeed used after **ne.** . . **que** in negative sentences. Here we don't contract them to de/d'.

Français	English
Je n'ai que **des** livres.	I only have books.
Ils n'achètent que **des** ordinateurs.	They only buy computers.
Il ne boit que **du** lait.	He drinks only milk.

No Articles Used After Ne... Ni... Ni

Français	English
Il **n'**a **ni** frères **ni** sœurs.	He has neither brothers nor sisters.
Je **n'**ai **ni** argent **ni** or.	I have neither money nor gold.
Nous **n'**avons **ni** chance **ni** puissance.	We have neither luck nor power.
Je **n'**aime **ni** la robe **ni** les chaussures.	I like neither the dress nor the shoes.

Exception: We **do** use **definite articles** with the verbs like aimer, adorer, détester and preferer etc in the above type of negation.

Français	English
Elle n'aime ni **les** chats ni **les** chiens.	She likes neither cats nor dogs.
Je ne préfère ni **les** huîtres ni **les** escargots.	I prefer neither oysters nor snails.
Il n'aime ni **le** pain ni **le** fromage.	He likes neither bread nor cheese.

Omission of Pas

Pas may be omitted in the negative sentences after **savoir, pouvoir, oser** and **cesser** when they are followed by an infinitive.

Français	English
Il ne sait que faire.	He doesn't know what to do.
Ils ne peuvent parler français.	They cannot speak French.
Vous n'osez partir de la maison.	You dare not leave the house.
Nous ne cessons de rire.	We cannot stop laughing.

Omission of Ne

While speaking in street/common language (la langue courante), French people quite often don't speak **"ne"** in the negative sentences.

Français	English
Je ne sais pas. → Je sais pas.	I don't know.
Ce n'est pas possible. → C'est pas possible.	It's not possible.
Ce n'est pas vrai. → C'est pas vrai.	That is not true.

Placement of Rien (Nothing) and Personne (Nobody)

In Simple Tenses

In simple tenses **"personne"** and **"rien"** follow the verb.

Français	English
Je ne mange **rien**.	I'm not eating anything.
Elle ne sait **rien**.	She knows nothing.
Tu n'aimes **personne** !	You don't like anyone!
Ils n'aident **personne**.	They're not helping anyone.

With Multiple Verbs Construction

"Personne" usually follows the infinitive, while **"rien"** follows the conjugated verb.

Français	English
Je ne peux voir **personne**.	I can see nobody. / I can't see anybody.
Elles ne veulent inviter **personne**.	They don't want to invite anyone.
Nous n'allons **rien** faire.	We are not going to do anything.
Elle ne veut **rien** manger.	She doesn't want to eat anything.

In Compound Tenses

"personne" follows the past participle, but **"rien"** follows the conjugated auxiliary verb.

Français	English
La police n'a vu **personne** dans la rue.	The police didn't see anyone on the street.
Nous n'avons **rien** fait pour notre pays.	We have done nothing for our country.
Je n'ai **rien** mangé car j'avais mal à l'estomac.	I ate nothing as I had a stomach ache.
Elle n'a rencontré **personne** pendant deux mois.	She hasn't met anybody for two months.

When "personne" and "rien" are used as **indirect objects**, **"ne"** precedes the verb and **"personne"** and **"rien"** succeed the preposition.

Français	English
Je **ne** parle à **personne.**	I don't talk to anyone.
Elle **n'**a fait attention à **personne.**	She did not pay attention to anyone.
Il **n'**a peur de **rien.**	He is not afraid of anything.
Nous **ne** sommes responsables de **rien.**	We are not responsible for anything.